

Unrest in Africa

In Kenya, the imposition of a state of emergency in 1952, in response to the Mau Mau (rebel) uprising, led to greater insurgency and the British rounding up of tens of thousands of Mau Mau suspects into detention camps. By 1956 the rebellion had been crushed, but the methods used by the British to regain control brought international condemnation. In central Africa, too, decolonization was born in violence. In Rhodesia, savage conflict erupted between the black majority and the fiercely racist white leadership, which had unilaterally declared independence in 1965.

The process of decolonization coincided with the new Cold War between the Soviet Union and the United States. The US became concerned that, as the European powers lost their colonies, Soviet-supported communist parties might achieve power in the new states. The US used substantial aid packages to encourage newly independent nations to adopt governments that aligned with the West. The Soviet Union deployed similar tactics in an effort to encourage new nations to join the communist bloc. Many resisted the pressure to be drawn into the Cold War and joined the “non-aligned movement.” This movement began out of a 1955 meeting in Bandung, Indonesia, involving 29 African and Asian countries. Member countries decided they would not be involved in alliances or defense pacts with the main world powers, but focus on internal development instead.

Terrorism in France

France was determined to maintain its political status in Algeria. When independence was not realized after World War II, war broke out between Algerian nationalists and French settlers. In 1958, the National Liberation Front (FLN), the main nationalist group, led several terrorist attacks, first in Algeria, then in Paris. The crisis led to the return to power of Charles de Gaulle, the wartime leader of the Free French. In 1960, de Gaulle, to the horror of the French settlers, agreed to emancipate Algeria. After

a long and bloody conflict in which an estimated 150,000 died, Algeria gained its independence in 1962.

Independence gained

During the 1960s and '70s, many of the countries that were once held as British colonies became independent states and joined the Commonwealth. The British Commonwealth, formed in 1931, became the successor to Britain's old empire, preserving Britain's global economic and political influence. In 1931 Britain extended dominion status to the already self-governing colonies of Canada (1867), Australia (1901), New Zealand (1907), and Newfoundland (1907). Britain and her dominions shared equal status, and they accepted the British monarch as head of the Commonwealth. In 1949 the British Commonwealth became “The Commonwealth,” a free and equal association of independent states, but the end of the empire was drawing near. Britain fought a war to retain the Falkland Islands in 1982, and Hong Kong continued as a British dependency until 1997.

Gandhi had a profound influence on world politics. Other peaceful resisters—such as Martin Luther King, Jr., and Tibet's Dalai Lama—emulated his methods. Around the world, the struggle for countries to secede from nations they belong to continues, as the likes of Scotland (United Kingdom), Quebec (Canada), and Palestine fight to be seen as nations in their own right. ■



Mau Mau suspects captured in Nairobi's Great Rift Valley, Kenya, in 1952 are led away, with their hands on their heads, to be questioned by police and possibly held in detention camps.